NOW PLAYING HERSELF



THE WOMAN COMES INTO HER OWN ON OTT AS THE FORMAT GIVES SPACE TO THE FEMALE CHARACTER, WRITER, CREATOR AND DIRECTOR

By SUHANI SINGH

IN 2017, stand-up comic Sumukhi Suresh pitched a show about a woman who is an obsessive romantic stalker. "I dreamt of playing the lead and not the lead's best friend. But I was told I didn't have the looks of a lead and asked whether I could carry a movie or show on my own," says Suresh. "The only way to prove them wrong was to create my own show." And soon enough there was *Pushpavalli*, in which Suresh explores a young woman's insecurities about her appearance and the incongruity it breeds in her behaviour even as she made viewers laugh. The Amazon Prime Video series drew acclaim for daring to build a show around a messy heroine. Five years later, women-centric web shows are not such an oddity.

Pretty much every streaming platform has had a popular show anchored by an actress or bunch of actresses. Disney+ HotStar has had two seasons of both *Aarya* (Sushmita Sen) and *Out of Love* (Rasika Dugal) and recently released *Human*, a medical drama with Shefali Shah and Kirti Kulhari helming it; Amazon Prime Video will release the third season of *Four More Shots Please!* later in 2022 and, last year, SonyLIV's *Maharani* had Huma Qureshi play a reluctant politician, with a career trajectory loosely reminiscent of Rabri Devi's. In 2021, AltBalaji, which created one of the first women-centric series in the Nimrat Kaur-starrer *The Test Case*, dropped *The Married Woman*, exploring a lesbian relationship. Netflix has a whole shebang slated for 2022: new seasons of *She* (Aaditi Pohankar) and *Masaba Masaba* (Masaba Gupta) besides *The Fame Game*, Madhuri Dixit-Nene's OTT debut, and *Mai*, featuring Sakshi Tanwar. Two months into 2022, ZEE5 has already released *Kaun Banegi Shikharwati* in January followed by crime thriller *Mithya* about